

AGAINST DOGMATISM: A CONTINUED DEFENSE OF SWITCH SIDE DEBATE

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Abstract: The debate about switch side debating – a practice that requires students participating in academic debate contests to argue on behalf of both the affirmative and negative sides of the resolution during a multiple-round tournament – has intensified with the introduction of critical and activist arguments in competitions. While the controversy over the ethics of publicly debating both sides of an issue has largely been closed, the social and pedagogical merits of the practice remain the subject of contentious argument. Against several recent critiques of switch side debating, this essay defends the continuing relevance and benefits of such an approach. In particular, it argues that true conviction is a result of debate rather than a pre-condition for it, that a limited form of argumentative pluralism is preferable to dogmatic assertions about what should be considered subject for advocacy, and that switching sides is a remedy for uncritical absolutism and intolerance.

Every truth has two sides. It is well to look at both sides before we commit ourselves to either side.

– Aesop's Fables¹

Although the value of competitive debating has been relatively uncontested, an important lingering question remains about how the format of debates should be

¹Aesop. (1992). Moral of "the mule". *Aesop's Fables* (Zipes, J., ed.). Signet Classics, p. 61.

structured in order to maximize the pragmatic, pedagogical, and social benefits of the practice. A structured activity that represents a microcosm of broader societal processes of deliberation, debate has always been as concerned with how students argue (the process of debate) as it has been with what is being argued about (the content). Traditionally, high school and collegiate debating has followed a switch-side blueprint that requires students to argue both for and against a given topic during the course of a season. As part of this process, it has been generally accepted that student debaters are allowed, if not encouraged, to “step outside of the box” and gain additional insight into controversial issues during contest rounds by arguing on the behalf of positions that they do not personally hold. However, with the emergence of increasingly widespread views that there are no isolated, neutral, and apolitical training grounds for argumentation, the merits of such “switch side” debating practices have been called into question. Some have argued that debaters should argue only from personal conviction because certain anterior concerns should be privileged over debate itself or because debating both sides of controversial issues risks persuading students to support dangerous ideas. Against these recent charges, many defenders of switch side debate have been silent. Yet, the practice of stepping outside of one’s own rigid beliefs and exposing their views to contrary arguments is one that still has considerable value and ought to be firmly defended.

Switching sides is a method that is integral to the success of debate as a deliberative and reflexive activity. No other component process than switch side debate contributes more greatly to the cultivation of a healthy ethic of tolerance and pluralism, generates the reasoned reflection necessary for critical thinking, or instills responsible and critical skepticism toward dominant systems of belief. The purpose of this essay is to mount a defense of the validity of switch-side debating in light of modern criticisms by drawing upon the existing body of literature related to the theory to build a case for its continued practice.

Practical, Pedagogical, and Social Benefits

Switch side debate (SSD) is an argumentative model that requires students to debate both the affirmative and negative sides of the resolution over the course of a multiple-round tournament. In practice, SSD requires that debaters' arguments are frequently divorced from personal conviction; in many cases students are required by the topic to take a position and argue vigorously on behalf of views that they disagree with. Debaters with ideological beliefs are thrust into the position of the devil's advocate, assuming the side of the opposition and needing to understand the arguments of the opposing view well enough to argue on their behalf. Instead of approaching the debate topic from the perspective of personal belief, students often choose arguments from a strategic and competitive perspective. Because of SSD, the purpose of debate is not to convince others to accept a certain argument as preferable or "true", but rather to choose the strongest and most intellectually rigorous position that has the greatest chance of prevailing under scrutiny (and thus earning a competitive victory). Policy debate, an activity with few formal rules and requirements, developed this norm of arguing both sides of a topic for pragmatic, pedagogical, and social reasons.

Practically, the contemporary format of tournament contests would be much more difficult to maintain if the tournament directors were not able to require that an equal number of competitors debate on the affirmative and negative in any given round. Were students free to choose their own sides, it seems likely that debaters who held strong views for or against the statement of the resolution would choose to debate exclusively on that side. Given the generally liberal leanings of the debate community and inevitable biases in topic construction, an unequal division between the sides would be unavoidable (Cripe, 1957). This would make pairing debate rounds much more difficult, if not impossible.

While such pragmatic justifications for SSD are persuasive, they are admittedly secondary to the greater consideration of pedagogy. Although it is certainly true that debate is a game and that its competitive elements are

indispensable sources of motivation for students who may otherwise be apathetic about academic endeavors, the overwhelming benefits of contest debating are the knowledge and skills taught through participation. The wins and losses are forgotten with the passage of time. However, the educational values of debate are so fundamental that they eventually become ingrained in the decision-making and thought processes of debaters, giving them a uniquely valuable durability. To this end, SSD is essential. The benefits of debating both sides have been noted by many authors over the past fifty years. To name but a few, SSD has been lauded for fostering tolerance and undermining bigotry and dogmatism (Muir, 1993), creating stronger and more knowledgeable advocates (Dybvig and Iversion, 2000), and fortifying the social forces of democracy by guaranteeing the expression of minority viewpoints (Day, 1966). Switching sides is a crucial element of debate's pedagogical benefit; it forms the gears that drive debate's intellectual motor.

Additionally, there are social benefits to the practice of requiring students to debate both sides of controversial issues. Dating back to the Greek rhetorical tradition and the tension between Plato and the Sophists, great value has been placed on the benefit of testing each argument relative to all others in the marketplace of ideas. Like those who argue on behalf of the efficiency-maximizing benefits of free market competition, it is believed that arguments are most rigorously tested (and conceivably refined and improved) when compared to all available alternatives. Even for beliefs that have seemingly been ingrained in consensus opinion or in cases where the public at-large is unlikely to accept a particular position, it has been argued that they should remain open for public discussion and deliberation (Mill, 1975).

Along these lines, the greatest benefit of switching sides, which goes to the heart of contemporary debate, is its inducement of critical thinking. Defined as "reasonable reflective thinking that is focused on deciding what to believe or do" (Ennis, 1987), critical thinking learned through debate teaches students not just how to advocate and

argue, but how to decide as well. Each and every student, whether in debate or (more likely) at some later point in life, will be placed in the position of the decision-maker. Faced with competing options whose costs and benefits are initially unclear, critical thinking is necessary to assess all the possible outcomes of each choice, compare its relative merits, and arrive at some final decision about which choice is preferable. In some instances, such as choosing whether to eat Chinese or Indian food for dinner, the importance of making the correct decision is minor. For many other decisions, however, the implications of choosing an imprudent course of action are potentially grave. Although the days of the Cold War are over, and the risk that “the next Pearl Harbor could be ‘compounded by hydrogen’” (Ehninger and Brockriede, 1978) is greatly reduced, the manipulation of public support before the invasion of Iraq in 2003 points to the continuing necessity of training a well-informed and critically-aware public (Zarefsky, 2007). In the absence of debate-trained critical thinking, uninformed politicians and manipulative leaders would be much more likely to draw the country, and possibly the world, into conflicts with incalculable losses in terms of human well-being. As Louis Rene Beres writes, “with such learning, we Americans could prepare...not as immobilized objects of false contentment, but as authentic citizens of an endangered planet” (2003). Thus, it is not surprising that critical thinking has been called “the highest educational goal of the activity” (Parcher, 1998).

While arguing from conviction can foster limited critical thinking skills, switching sides is necessary to sharpen debate’s critical edge and ensure that decisions are made in a reasoned manner instead of being driven by ideology. Debaters trained in SSD are more likely to evaluate both sides of an argument before arriving at a conclusion and are less likely to dismiss potential arguments based on prior beliefs (Muir, 1993). In addition, debating both sides teaches “conceptual flexibility,” where decision-makers are more likely to reflect upon the beliefs that are held before coming to a final opinion (Muir, 1993). Exposed to many arguments on each side of an issue, debaters learn

that public policy is characterized by extraordinary complexity that requires careful consideration before action. Finally, these arguments are confirmed by the preponderance of empirical research demonstrating a link between competitive SSD and critical thinking (Allen, Berkowitz, Hunt and Loudon, 1999; Colbert, 2002).

The theory and practice of SSD has value beyond the limited realm of competitive debate as well. For the practitioners and students of rhetoric understanding how individuals come to form opinions about subjects and then attempt to persuade others is of utmost importance. Although the field of communication has established models that attempt to explain human decision-making, such as the Rational Argumentation Theory and others (Cragen and Shields, 1998), the practice of SSD within competitive debate rounds is a real-world laboratory where argumentative experiments are carried out thousands of times over during the course of a single year-long season. The theory of SSD has profound implications for those who study how individuals are persuaded as well as how advocates should go about the process of forming their own personal beliefs and attempting to persuade others.

Debate About Debate

Since its inception, the practice of debating both sides in academic contests has consistently remained a “fruitful subject for controversy” (Ehninger, 1958) and complaints about the mode of debate are “as old as the activity itself” (Keith, 2007). While many members of the debate community support the practice, SSD has been the subject of recurring criticism (Murphy, 1957; Ehninger, 1958; Greene and Hicks, 2005; Massey, 2006). In particular, one landmark incident that laid the groundwork for contemporary debate about debate was the boycotting of the 1954 national topic by the U.S. military academics. On that topic, “Resolved: That the United States should extend diplomatic recognition to the communist government of China,” defending the Affirmative required debaters to advocate a position that was contrary to the United States’ official policy of containment. Conservatives, especially

those that were part of the U.S. armed forces (who adhere to restrictions on their public political views), objected to such a position as ethically and educationally indefensible, and withdrew their teams from competition (English, Llano, Mitchell, Morrison, Rief and Woods, 2007). The resulting stir generated national discussion, including a feature in the *New York Times* (Greene and Hicks, 2005). This single incident revealed the strong beliefs held by people on both sides of the issue. More generally, it was reflective of how rigidly these institutions adhered to strict guidelines about their educational mission and discouraged the expression of alternative points of view. Although the “Red China” controversy was undoubtedly situational and determined by its particular place in history, the debate over that topic and the reaction of many participants points toward the larger significance of SSD and the intensity of all sides involved.

In the ten years following the China topic dispute, the debate over the merits of SSD continued to rage. Debate coaches from around the country chimed in, objecting to the ethical (Murphy, 1957) and pedagogical (Ehninger, 1958) implications of SSD. Yet, after a decade’s worth of discussion, the ethical charge² was declared defeated by a quantitative survey of debate coaches’ opinions, which revealed that an overwhelming consensus agreed that SSD was ethically sound (Klopf and McCrosky, 1964). However, as Klopf and McCrosky readily admit, “The controversy over the pedagogical value of debating both sides hardly has begun.” Over the next thirty years, the proponents of SSD struck back, providing a series of arguments about the vast educational benefits of the practice noted above and, as can be inferred from the lack of academic writing defending the prior criticisms of SSD, gradually achieved mainstream acceptance within the policy debate community.

² That switch-sides debating is unethical because it is tantamount to lying. Advocates of this belief state that debaters should not publicly declare beliefs that they themselves do not hold. Efficiently characterized by Richard Murphy’s famous statement that “A public statement is a public commitment” (1957).

Theory and Practice

The practice of competitive debate has undergone substantial changes within the past fifteen years. The gradual introduction of two new arguments forms, the critique (or German “Kritik”) and activism, have shaped both argumentative practices in debate rounds and the “meta-thinking” about debate that influences the community’s perception of the value of SSD.

The activist position represents a dramatic shift in the purpose of debate from deciding which team advocates the preferable policy option to which team has the superior political purpose. Judges are expected to vote for activist arguments because they believe in them and wish to endorse their ideas. In this respect activism is also controversial because it implicitly calls into question the viability of switch side model of debate. Conviction is a necessary component of affirming a particular political approach outside of its isolated hypothetical position in a debate round. Students on activist teams are viewed as genuine advocates of their positions and frequently do not alternate between affirming and negating the resolution, instead choosing to adopt a consistent position between rounds, tournaments, and sometimes even entire topics. While it may be theoretically possible for activist debaters to utilize the SSD method, it has not played out this way in practice. Students from some schools have essentially maintained the same argument over the course of most of the last decade.

The development of the critique and activism as competitive debate practices has been accompanied by new and renewed insights about the theory of SSD. In particular, three arguments have been the most prevalent. First, the argument about convictions has re-emerged on the other side of the ideological spectrum. As the influence of postmodern literature has become increasingly popular in debate, more and more students and coaches have accepted its tenets of micro-political disruption and skepticism toward traditional means of social change. Now, liberals (instead of the conservatives on the 1954 “engage China” topic) are objecting to the practice of SSD because it forces student to advocate “dirty” bureaucratic politics through the state.

Second, critics of SSD have charged that the practice has a moderating effect on students' beliefs, drawing them toward the political center over time. While this may not necessarily be a bad thing, some have argued that this is a form of "cooptation" that strengthens the "dominant ideology" latent within debate practices (Massey, 2006). Third and most prevalently, some have argued that the practice of debating both sides should be critically scrutinized because of the way it contributes to the moral development of the debater as a subject.

In 2005 Ronald Greene and Darrin Hicks, drawing on the existing body of theory relating to SSD, wrote an article criticizing the claim advanced earlier by Day that debating both sides is the "highest ethical act" (1966) because it subordinates personal convictions to a belief in the process of debate as crucial sustenance for the democratic system. Greene and Hicks argued that SSD problematically contributes to the ethical self-fashioning of debaters, a process by which those who embrace pluralism and openness to both sides are conceived of as the ideal liberal citizen. Switching sides in debate, after all, is premised upon the free and open expression of ideas. During the Cold War, the issue of "free speech" was a primary distinction between the societies of the United States and Soviet Union. According to Greene and Hicks, the fashioning of citizens around the norms cultivated by SSD contributed to an exceptionalist form of liberalism.

Continued Importance of SSD

Given the long, contested history of switch side debating and the recent criticisms of the practice emerging from the critical and activist schools of argument, it is necessary to examine the continuing merits of requiring debaters to advocate both sides of an issue. Due to the "closed" nature of the controversy over ethics (Klopf and McCrosky, 1964) and the focus of contemporary discussion, this essay primarily responds to *pedagogical* and *social* critiques of SSD. In particular, three arguments against debating both sides are addressed in depth. Opponents of SSD have charged that switch side debate defuses radical

activism by moderating the beliefs of debaters, forces students to speak on behalf of dangerous ideas, and contributes to a form of political morality that fuels American exceptionalism (Hicks & Greene, 2005; Massey, 2006³). While this is hardly an exhaustive list of current criticisms of SSD, these critiques raise issues that cut straight to the heart of the debate about debate. In responding to these criticisms and developing a defense of SSD, this essay builds the case for the continuing utility of debating both sides. As a method of teaching students to engage in the crucial educational practice of critical thinking, SSD is virtually unparalleled. Thus, while there may be some minor drawbacks to SSD, the benefits are strong enough to justify its practice.

Don't Fear Cooption

Critics of SSD have argued that debating both sides is a tactic of cooption by dominant beliefs because speaking on behalf of "evil" ideas moderates extreme views. Instead of sharpening and refining the prior beliefs of debaters, the argument goes, engaging in switch side debating changes the beliefs of students, slowly drawing them "close[r] to the middle" (Massey, 2006). Mirroring the broader critical move toward a "depoliticized expression of struggles," they argue that this is undesirable because only extreme views are "pure" in the sense that they avoid entanglement in bureaucratic structures of government (Boggs, 1997). Essentially, the argument boils down to "brainwashing": switching sides causes students to abandon their original (presumably correct) beliefs in favor of more moderate and less politically effective ideas.

Three responses effectively dispatch with this criticism. First, the *foundational premise* of the case for

³ While eDebate may not be the ideal location for determining the debate community's perspectives on controversy, I have chosen to use it because of the relative lack of recent published work on switch-side debate. Although it invariably represents only a small portion of contemporary thinking on this subject, it still provides a useful and otherwise difficult to access snapshot of debate's theoretical history.

switch side debating indicts the notion that true conviction can be held prior to a rigorous analysis of all sides of an issue through debating both sides. As far back as A. C. Baird (1955), proponents of switch side debating have argued that conviction was a result of reasoned consideration of the issues surrounding a particular policy rather than a precondition for it. For instance, Baird argues, "Sound conviction... should stem from mature reflection. Discussion and debate facilitate the maturing of such reflective thinking and conviction" (1955). Many debaters, especially those new to high school or collegiate debate, do not yet have calcified opinions about many controversial subjects. Instead, they develop their beliefs over time, as they spend time thinking through the nuances of each relevant argument in preparation for competitive debating. By arguing on behalf of both the affirmative and the negative sides of a given resolution, switch side debaters are exposed to many avenues to test their initial thoughts on controversial subjects.

Traditionally, the formation of belief in this manner has coincided more closely with the meaning of "conviction." Defined as beliefs that are formed as a result of "exposing fallacies" through the "give-and-take of rebuttal," sound convictions can only be truly generated by the reflexive thinking spurred by debating both sides. While some students may honestly believe that they have thoroughly considered the merits of a particular opinion before arguing for or against it in a debate, experimenting with ideas in a competitive SSD is still a necessary endeavor. Only in debate, a relatively isolated political space, are many arguments able to be presented in an ideally open, no-holds-barred manner (Coverstone 1995). Moreover, when faced with the prospect of being forced to advocate a position, students receive the necessary motivation (through competitive and other impulses) to research the complexities of a given subject. Also, through the requirement of advocacy students are encouraged to actively listen, a crucial element of rich argumentative engagement (Lacy 2002). In the end, the switch side debater emerges with a deeper understanding of more sides of an issue and may be ready to

come to some degree of conclusion and conviction about which side to support.

Conviction generated through debating both sides is preferable to dogmatic and non-negotiable assertions of belief (Baird 1955). Switching sides grounds belief in reasonable reflective thinking; it teaches that decisions should not be rendered until all positions and possible consequences have been considered in a reasoned manner. This method is closely linked to the value that debate places on critical thinking. Unsurprisingly, many authors have noted the importance of SSD for generating such rigorous decision-making skills (Muir 1993; Parcher 1998; Rutledge 2002; Speice & Lyle 2003; English, Llano, Mitchell, Morrison, Rief and Woods 2007). The critical thinking taught by SSD provides a strong defense against dangerous forms of cooption. Over time, certain arguments will prevail over others only if they have a strong enough logical foundation to withstand thorough scrutiny. Debaters will change their minds to support the “moderate” side of certain positions only if—after reasoned reflection and sound conviction—doing so is found to be preferable. While such a “marketplace of ideas” may be marked by some imperfections, one of its most effective incarnations is undoubtedly in academic debate rounds. There, appeals to wealth, status, and power are minimized by a focus on logic and formal rules, which protect the ability of all participants to contribute in an honest and open manner. As a result, it should be assumed that the insights generated through debate’s dialectic process will be generally correct and that any shifting beliefs are the reflection of a social good (the replacement of false ideas with truth).

Conceiving of conviction in this manner redefines the role of debate into what Baird calls an “educational procedure”: the formation of a pedagogical playground to experiment with alternative ideas and coalesce assertions and unwarranted beliefs into sound conviction (1966). Treating debate as a training ground for advocacy and decision-making has several benefits: it allows debaters the conceptual flexibility to experiment with minority and extreme ideas, protects them from outside influences, and

buys them time before they are forced to publicly put forward their opinions (Coverstone 1995). As a result, the primary focus of the activity shifts from arguing to deciding, giving critical thinking its crucial importance. A fundamental premise of the anti-SSD's claim about cooption is thus arraigned: it is impossible to lose one's convictions before they have truly been discovered.

Second, the link between debating both sides and the moderation of student's beliefs is far from clear. Admittedly, there has been little to no formal empirical research investigating this connection. Yet, it seems equally likely that SSD may bolster the original beliefs of debaters (especially if they held beliefs that are found to be desirable after all related issues have been discussed) by allowing them to develop thoughtful responses to the best arguments against their original position. If a debater's beliefs are altered because he or she realizes that he or she has made an error in their initial conviction, then that seems to be a clear benefit of SSD, rather than a drawback. If a position is so weak that debaters alter their opinion about it as a result of temporary advocacy, then the worth of these convictions must surely be met with a high degree of skepticism.

Moreover, even if SSD does moderate the beliefs of debaters, this alone is not evidence of an insidious plot to undermine radical activism. The statistical notion of regression to the mean can explain this phenomenon. As with the statistical tendency for extreme results to become more moderate over time, when beginning from intellectually extreme positions debaters can only become more moderate over time. Thus, any form of debating—from conviction or SSD—is likely to have the same moderating effect.

Third, there is an important question of means. Even the best activist intentions have little practical utility as long as they remain purely cordoned off in the realm of theoretical abstractions. Creating programs of action that seek to produce material change should be the goal of any revolutionary project. Frequently, for strategies for change, the devil lies in the details. Lacking a plausible mechanism to enact reforms, many have criticized critical theory as

being a “fatally flawed enterprise” (Jones 1999). For activists, learning the skills to successfully negotiate hazardous political terrain is crucial. They must know when and when not to compromise, negotiate, and strike political alliances in order to be successful. The pure number of failed movements in the past several decades demonstrates the severity of the risk assumed by groups who do not focus on refining their preferred means of change. For example, some have argued that anti-nuclear and other peace movements have been largely ineffective because of their inability to coalesce around plans and methods for change (Martin, 1990).

Given the importance of strategies for change, SSD is even more crucial. Debaters trained by debating both sides are substantially more likely to be effective advocates than those experienced only in arguing on behalf of their own convictions. For several reasons, SSD instills a series of practices that are essential for a successful activist agenda. First, SSD creates more knowledgeable advocates for public policy issues. As part of the process of learning to argue both sides, debaters are forced to understand the intricacies of multiple sides of the argument considered. Debaters must not only know how to research and speak on behalf of their own personal convictions, but also for the opposite side in order to defend against attacks of that position. Thus, when placed in the position of being required to publicly defend an argument, students trained via SSD are more likely to be able to present and persuasively defend their positions. Second, learning the nuances of all sides of a position greatly strengthens the resulting convictions of debaters, their ability to anticipate opposing arguments, and the effectiveness of their attempts to locate the crux, nexus and loci of arguments. As noted earlier, conviction is a *result*, not a *prerequisite* of debate. Switching sides and experimenting with possible arguments for and against controversial issues, in the end, makes students more likely to ground their beliefs in a reasoned form of critical thinking that is durable and robust in the face of knee-jerk criticisms. As a result, even though it may appear to be inconsistent with advocacy, SSD “actually created stronger advocates” that are more likely to

be successful in achieving their goals (Dybvig and Iverson, 2000).

Proponents of abandoning SSD and returning to debating from conviction should take note. Undoubtedly, many of their ideas would be beneficial if enacted and deserve the support of activist energies. However, anti-SSD critics should consider the important question of how to translate good ideas into practice. By teaching students to privilege their own personal beliefs prior to a thorough engagement with all sides of an issue, debating from conviction produces activists that are more likely to be politically impotent. By positing that debaters should bring prior beliefs to the table in a rigid manner and assuming that compromising is tantamount to giving in to cooptation, the case of debating from conviction undercuts the tactics necessary for forging effective coalitional politics. Without such broad-based alliances, sustainable political changes will likely be impossible (Best & Kellner, 2001).

Tolerating the Intolerable: A Defense of Limited Argumentative Pluralism

A second criticism of SSD that has recently been voiced is that, because the practice places some restrictions upon what debaters may argue (by forcing them to take the position of the both the affirmative and the negative), it requires students to become advocates for certain intolerable ideas that should be “off limits” for discussion. For example, the increasingly prevalent usage of postmodern arguments in collegiate debate rounds has caused many teams to argue that they should not be forced to defend the “dirty” bureaucratic politics of the federal government (Solt 2004).

However, the relevance of argumentation for advancing tolerant politics cannot be underestimated. The willingness to be open to alternative views has a material impact on respect for difference in at least two primary ways. First, rendering certain beliefs as “off limits” from debate and the prohibition of ideas from the realm of contestation is conceptually indistinct from the physical exclusion of people from societal practices. Unlike racial or gendered concerns, certain groups of people (the religious,

minority political parties, etc.) are defined almost exclusively by the arguments that they adhere to. To deem these views unspeakable or irrelevant is to functionally deny whole groups of people access to public deliberation. Second, argument, as individual advocacy, is an expression of belief. It has the potential to persuade members of the public to either support or oppose progressive politics. Belief itself is an accurate indicator of the way individuals will choose to act—with very real implications for openness, diversity and accommodation. Thus, as a precursor to action, argument is an essential starting point for campaigns of tolerance.

Argumentative pluralism can be defined as the proper tolerance for the expression of a diversity of ideas (Scriven 1975). Contrary to monism, pluralism holds that there are many potential beliefs in the world and that each person has the ability to determine for himself or herself whether these beliefs hold true. In the argumentative context, pluralism requires that participants in a debate or discussion recognize the right of others to express their beliefs, no matter how objectionable. The key here is expression: although certain beliefs may be more “true” than others in the epistemic sense, each should have equal access (at least initially) to forums of deliberation. It is important to conceptually distinguish pluralism from its commonly confused but only loosely connected counterpart, relativism. To respect the right of others to hold different beliefs does not require that they are all considered equal. Such tolerance ends at the intellectual level of each individual being able to hold their own belief. Indeed, as Muir writes, “It [pluralism] implies neither tolerance of actions based on those beliefs nor respecting the content of the beliefs” (288). Thus, while a pluralist may acknowledge the right for some to hold exclusionary views, he or she need not endorse racism or anti-Semitism, or the right to exclude itself.

Even when limited to such a narrow realm of diversity, argumentative pluralism holds great promise for a politics based on understanding and accommodation that runs contrary to the dominant forces of economic, political, and social exclusion. Pluralism requires that individuals

acknowledge opposing beliefs and arguments by forcing an understanding that personal convictions are not universal. Instead of blindly asserting a position as an “objective Truth,” advocates tolerate a multiplicity of perspectives, allowing a more panoramic understanding of the issue at hand (Mitchell and Suzuki, 2004). In doing so, the advocates frequently understand that there are persuasive arguments to be had on both sides of an issue. As a result, instead of advancing a cause through moralistic posturing or appeals to a falsely assumed universality (which, history has shown, frequently become justifications for scapegoating and exclusion), these proponents become purveyors of reasoned arguments who attempt to persuade others through deliberation.

A clear example of this occurs in competitive academic debate. Switch-side debating has profound implications for pluralism. Instead of being personally invested in the truth and general acceptance of a position, debaters use arguments instrumentally, as tools, and as pedagogical devices in the search for larger truths. Beyond simply recognizing that more than one side exists for each issue, switch-side debate advances the larger cause of equality by fostering tolerance and empathy toward difference. Setting aside their own “ego-identification,” students realize that they must listen and understand their opponent’s arguments well enough to become advocates on behalf of them in future debates (Muir, 1993). Debaters assume the position of their opponents and understand how and why the position is constructed as it is. As a result, they often come to understand that a strong case exists for opinions that they previously disregarded. Recently, advocates of switch side debating have taken the case of the practice a step further, arguing that it, “originates from a civic attitude that serves as a bulwark against fundamentalism of all stripes” (English, Llano, Mitchell, Morrison, Rief and Woods, 2007). Debating practices that break down exclusive, dogmatic views may be one of the most robust checks against violence in contemporary society.

Undoubtedly, there are many who reject argumentative pluralism in all or nearly all cases. Absolutists maintain that there are certain positions where no other side exists or where one side is of such a minority opinion that it does not warrant being the subject of debate. For those who hold a mainstream political view, statements such as, “the State is beneficial and anarchy would be chaos,” “capitalist globalization is inevitable,” or, in the most extreme, “human life has value,” are taken as givens. For pluralists, the previous statements can be true but still be open to debate. For argumentative monists, such positions are so “true” that further discussion would not only be a waste of time, but may also risk changing the minds of some of the debaters to be more tolerant of a dangerous position (as discussed above). In academic debate, a substantial amount of controversy has existed in recent years over the state-centric nature of policy resolutions (the subject of debate). Liberals complain that being required to debate about state politics defuses radicalism by teaching students that bureaucratic politics is the means to all ends (Massey, 2006). This is the flip-side of the previous discussion of absolutism: critics can be so convinced of their positions, even if in the minority, that they refuse discussion of dominant principles altogether.

To preserve an open and accessible space of deliberation, limits need to be placed on the ability of participants to use violence or coercion to prevent others from voicing their own opinions. Some groups are so convinced of their position that they are willing to do anything, including forcefully silencing opposition, to ensure that their argument wins. Thus, some degree of exclusion is inevitable—the relevant questions are only who does that silencing and what circumstances it occurs under. As Ruth Lessl Shively, professor of political science at Texas A&M University notes:

The most radical skepticism ends in the most radical conservatism. In other words, a refusal to judge among ideas and activities is, in the end, an endorsement of the status quo... To fully support political contest, one must fully support some uncontested rules and reasons. (2000)

Violence seeks to destroy the open circulation of ideas that generate the progression towards truth. The arguments that prevail in an atmosphere of coercion are those promoted by the powerful elite, not the most intellectually sound. To ensure effective deliberation, certain communicative norms must be established to govern the conduct of participants. Even though the elaboration of clear rules may sometimes result in the exclusion of certain perspectives, it is a necessary means to protect the greater end of productive debate.

A second exception to the rule of free expression must be made to limit irrelevant discussion and establish a common starting point for debate. In the rhetorical tradition, the belief in the necessity of a mutual topic of disagreement, known as *stasis* (meaning “standing” and derived from a Greek word meaning “to stand still”), has a long history dating back to Aristotle. Through several modes of proceeding, the topic of controversy between interlocutors is established and an implicit contract—that here is the shared point of disagreement—is created. Without *stasis*, opponents may argue back and forth without really disagreeing with each other because they are not truly speaking about the same subject. For example, when one debater argues that the United States should refuse to negotiate with North Korea to avoid legitimating its harmful human rights policies and the opponent responds that President Clinton’s accommodation of North Korea in the 1990s was the source of its current human rights dilemma, there is no true disagreement. Each position can be entirely true without discounting the other. In this instance, the truth-generating function of deliberation is short-circuited. To eliminate errors, fallacies must gradually be replaced by truths, correct positions must win out over incorrect ones, and strong arguments must gain more acceptance than weak ideas. This process requires conflict; it necessitates rejection. To determine that something is “true” requires that its converse is “false.” The statement that “snow is cold” requires the dismissal of its contrary. Such choices can only be made when there is a point of disagreement for debate to revolve around. Without *stasis*,

the productive potential of deliberation is profoundly undermined.

To avoid this scenario of “two ships passing in the night,” argumentation scholars have recognized the importance of a mutual agreement to disagree and have attempted to create guidelines to facilitate productive discussion. “Some agreed upon end or goal must be present to define and delimit the evaluative ground within which the interchange is to proceed,” writes Douglas Ehninger, “When such ground is lacking, *argument itself* ... becomes impossible” (1958). Shively concurs, stating that, “we must agree about what it is that is being debated before we can debate it” (2000). In the academic context, policy debates create stasis by utilizing a year-long resolution that sets the topic for discussion. Affirmative teams must present a topical advocacy (one that fits within the bounds of the resolution) or they are procedurally disqualified. In public forums, the task falls upon moderators and discussion facilitators to set clear lines of relevance. Advocates, who frequently have strategic political incentives to avoid direct disagreement, need to be institutionally constrained by the framework for discussion.

A position that favors a limited form of argumentative pluralism undermines the claims made by those who oppose SSD and wish to render certain controversial issues “off limits” from debate. Limits should be placed on the content of debate only because such choices as to what is debatable are inevitable, and, given that, it is preferable to choose the path that best protects the forum for deliberation by minimizing exclusion. The arbitrary choice about what content should and should not be “up for debate” threatens to render deliberation impossible—either all issues are up for debate, or none can be.

An Antidote to Exceptionalism

A third criticism of SSD is an argument linking the practice of debating both sides to the development of societal norms that reinforce American exceptionalism. While originally a limited and context-dependent claim, this line of argument has been expanded to argue that the dominant

practice of debate colludes with forces of domination that seek to marginalize and silence alternative methods and styles of communication (Ellis 2004; Massey 2006). In 2005, Ronald Greene and Darrin Hicks, drawing on the existing body of theory relating to SSD, wrote an article claiming that debating both sides “helps liberalism create a governing field” between an individual’s personal convictions and their belief in the process of deliberation and debate (2005). Drawing on the case study of the previously discussed 1954 “Red China” controversy, in which several debate programs boycotted the topic based on ideological opposition to engaging the communist nation, Greene and Hicks demonstrated that, during the Cold War, SSD colluded with forces of liberalism to contribute to exceptionalism. They argue that this is the case for two reasons. First, during this period of time, the idea of “free” speech emerged as a way for the United States to distinguish itself from others and claim a moral superiority over closed societies. As part of many liberal elements of society, the promotion of free speech allowed the United States to posit itself as the bearer of reason and civility in opposition to the Soviet Union. Second, Greene and Hicks criticized the shift to process conviction advocated by Day, who argued that debating both sides of a given issue is the “highest ethical act” because it places absolute faith in the “free and full expression” of the democratic process of debate (1966). They claimed that Day’s subordination of personal convictions to a second-order conviction in the belief in debate as a process provided critical sustenance to societal norms governing the proper behavior of democratic citizens. Instead of providing an epistemic defense of SSD (in that it facilitated good decision-making or critical thinking), Day’s model of SSD was argued to be preferable because it best met the defining characteristics of democracy. As part of this, Day’s defense of SSD shifted the order of conviction from the personal (“I say what I believe”) to the process (“I do not always say what I believe, because I believe in the benefits of switch-side debate”). A necessary component of a firm belief in the process of SSD is the norm of “free and full expression” (Day 1966). During the Cold War, the American promotion

of free speech, as opposed to the repression and restrictions imposed on people living behind the “Iron Curtain,” was a key element of the case for the superiority of democratic society. Greene and Hicks picked up on this theme, arguing that:

By instantiating a desire for full and free expression, the pedagogical technique of debating both sides became a mechanism by which the student-debater-citizen becomes an exceptional ‘American’ – the bearer of universal norms of liberal democracy. (2005)

Thus, by debating both sides, democracy was sustained on the level of an individual’s self-fashioning which, as was very prominent at the time, contained an element of exceptionalist thinking about liberal values vis-à-vis communism. Additionally, Greene and Hicks noted that, during the debates over the “Red China” issue, there was a widespread fear that affirming such a topic would turn the American youth into communist sympathizers (Greene & Hicks 2005). Instead of questioning the core liberal belief inherent in such a claim (that sympathizing with communism should be rejected), the defenders of SSD chose not to take issue with this claim and instead only questioned whether the link to such an outcome was valid. The pro-SSD advocates claimed, along the lines of Baird, that debating both sides would produce a stronger conviction that would be impervious to communist propaganda—a reinforcement of liberalism.

In contemporary debate, others have taken this charge much further, to its logical extreme. Teams participating in debate rounds arguing on behalf of extreme positions, such as radical critiques of humanism, conventional morality, or the state, have drawn upon the work of Greene and Hicks to claim that SSD dangerously risks allowing debate to become a “form of cultural technology re-affirming a commitment to American Exceptionalism and global domination” (Massey, 2006). To do so, they extend the argument made in “Lost Convictions” in two ways. First, they expand the scope of its analysis beyond that of the Cold War and “Red China” controversy

and apply it to contemporary debate practice. Second, they explicitly connect American exceptionalism to the worst instances of U.S. global violence: the “kill-to-save” mentality of American soldiers in the Vietnam war, the preventive invasion of Iraq, and the unending “war on terrorism” that prioritizes national security over all else. Some have gone so far as to claim that the practice of switch side debate, revolving around state-centric issues (as mandated by the resolution), is meant to produce more effective policy wonks, imperial planners, and even engineers of genocide (Ellis 2004).

The extension and expansion of the previous claims of Greene and Hicks is dubious. Many of the elements of Greene and Hicks position are undoubtedly true. Like any principled approach to communication, SSD is laden with ideological presuppositions and biases. It presumes that the marketplace of ideas operates with a degree of efficacy, that democratic and deliberative approaches to problem-solving produce strong outcomes, and that there is a gap between the “private” debate round and the “public” realm of advocacy-after-conviction.

However, the arguments in “Lost Convictions” alone should not be read as a sweeping indictment of SSD for two reasons. First, Greene and Hicks make a specific and context-dependent claim about the Cold War that cannot be easily applied to contemporary discussion of the merits of SSD. 1954 was a time of McCarthyism and anti-Communist witch-hunts. It was quite possible then that one justification for debating both sides was a re-affirmation of liberalism against the communists. Now, in the midst of the “war on terrorism,” widespread restrictions on civil liberties, and President Bush’s mantra of “with us or against us,” it seems that the opposite is more true. Fidelity to the American cause is performed through the willing silence of its citizens. Dissent is quelled, and the public is encouraged to view the world through the singular lens of “freedom” against the forces of terrorism. Debating both sides—and lacking immediate conviction—is a sign of weakness and waffling in the face of imminent threats to national security. Thus, in the contemporary context, to reject SSD and promote argument

only through conviction is far more conducive to supporting American exceptionalism than debating multiple sides is as a liberal democratic justification.

Second, the fact that certain communicative practices like SSD are implicated in operations of power does not alone make them undesirable. Consistent with the Foucauldian basis of such a criticism, one cannot simply assert that power is a monolithic entity that can be deemed either “good” or “bad.” Instead, it is imperative to examine the “specificity of ... practices in order to delineate their forces and effects” (Muckelbauer 2000). Many actions were taken during the Cold War under the pretense that they would contribute in some way to the case for U.S. superiority over the Soviet Union. For example, it could be argued that the racial integration of schools in the United States was complicit with a narrative of plurality and openness that was, in at least some ways, exceptional. Does this make the integration of schools undesirable? Assuredly not. Bracketed off from the benefits derived from SSD, the interweaving of the practice with liberalism may be a cause for some concern. However, once the advantages of such an approach are considered, they do not alone merit a wholesale rejection of the process. Greene and Hicks acknowledge this when they write that, “In a world increasingly dominated by fundamentalism (religious and otherwise) the development of a respect for pluralism, tolerance and free speech remains politically valuable” (2005). Yes, as instructors and practitioners of debate, it is our responsibility to remain cognizant of precisely what type of “moral development” is being taught. But, once that awareness has been raised, the fact that it may not be totally neutral, itself an impossible goal, does not warrant abandonment of the switch-sides approach.

The arguments advanced by vocal critics of switch side debating are susceptible to several other responses. First, as have been previously argued by Stannard (2006), many of the processes that have contributed to American exceptionalism—globalization, infiltration of academic institutions by agents of imperialism, etc.—are on-going, inevitable, and independent of the institution of competitive

debate. As Alan Coverstone has noted, the disengagement of the public from political participation and adoption of a pure “spectator mentality” has now become the “predominant mode” of politics (2005). Many citizens attentive to political developments see an American politics susceptible to being overtaken by administrations bent on pursuing illiberal policies while wrapping themselves in the clothing of liberalism.

Given the now almost all-consuming exceptionalist mantra, debate is one of the last arenas that reward anti-institutional thinking and oppositional rhetoric (Stannard, 2006). It is a tremendous “stretch” to attribute the causal source of exceptionalism to debate (Lacy, 2006). Debate isn’t compulsory. Nothing in the activity makes students participate. Once involved, there are no thought-police who control the content of students’ speeches. Those who argue otherwise show a profound lack of respect for the magnitude of violence that their comparisons draw likeness to. Instead, the exact opposite seems defensible: a major and endemic problem that contributes to American exceptionalism is the *lack* of debate at all levels of society. Stannard agrees, warning:

Don’t throw the baby out with the bathwater. Instead, seek to expand this method of deliberation to those who will use it to liberate themselves... If capitalism corrupts debate, well, then I say we save debate. (2006)

The proper task of critics is not to retreat into speaking only from conviction. It is to strive to expand SSD to new avenues and to make ideas that were once considered dogma contestable. The very nature of the approach acts as a counter-weight to imperialism and “foster[s] resistance to domination” (Stannard, 2006).

Second, switch side debate’s emphasis on tolerance and empathy, which has been noted by many authors (Sanders, 1982; Muir, 1993; Bellon, 2000; Lacy, 2002), may indeed by one of the strongest “antidotes” to the disease of exceptionalism (Mitchell & Suzuki, 2004). Debate combines a commitment to reason and logic over emotive and political appeals, a priority placed upon quality research, and

vigorous norms of openness and plurality to create a forum where unwarranted and inappropriate forms of exceptionalism cannot survive. English, Llano, Mitchell, Morrison, Reif and Woods have referred to this deliberative attitude as a “bulwark against fundamentalism of *all stripes*” (2007). SSD teaches that no argument is “off limits,” that issues are more complex than black and white, and that reflection and contemplation are preferable to rash and preemptive decision-making. It is thus no surprise, as the Debate Authors Working Group has noted, that many of the most vocal contemporary critics of the Bush administration’s exceptionalist (and debatably imperialist) policies, including lawyer Neal Katyal and law professor Laurence Tribe, received a portion of their training in the pedagogical bullpen of debate.

In particular, SSD is an especially effective tool to combat the “with us or against us” absolutism of contemporary neoconservative ideology. Debating both sides increases debater’s appreciation of the arguments made by the opposition (English, Llano, Mitchell, Morrison, Rief and Woods, 2007). Oftentimes, as is frequently the case with complex issues, a reasonable party may conclude that two positions, which are polar opposites may each contain an element of truth. It is revealed that a compromised position is preferable to both extremes and that the discrete “with us” and “against us” stances are arbitrary and inaccurate categorizations. As far back as Day (1966), there is an emphasis on the expression of minority view points. Debating both sides allows debaters the intellectual flexibility (through un-attachment to their personal beliefs) to express dissent and critique even the most firmly established policies and norms. This ensures a vibrant activist influence in debate that can provide at least a modest check against the most extreme governmental abuses.

Conclusion

The popularization of certain strands of thinking has contributed to the controversy over switch side debating in new ways. However, after consideration, none of the major criticisms are sufficiently sound to merit a rejection of the

practice. The foundational claims of the pro-SSD position, that conviction is a *product* of debate, that the social good is served by replacing falsities with progressive truths by keeping all issues open for discussion, and that debating both sides is an act of tolerance that poses a potent challenge to the forces of exceptionalism, remain strong. Even if some elements of these criticisms are true, they still must be balanced against the strong benefits of the switch side approach. Given the advantages for activists and advocates for change, the creation of strong decision-making and critical thinking skills, the pluralistic method of argumentation, and the promotion of tolerance inspired by debating both sides, an on-balance assessment of SSD must conclude that the practice has both pedagogical and social benefits that should not be rejected.

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